

Post-incident review PIR-2025-037

Data Warehouse: delayed processing

Contoso Platform Engineering. Fictional sample data.

Summary

On 19 August 2025, Data Warehouse experienced delayed processing in staging (Southeast Asia) for about 12 minutes. Users posted about the problem on social media, and the support team escalated it. Investigation found that a pipeline overwrote the environment variable that pointed the service at its cache cluster.

Impact

Users of Data Warehouse saw delayed processing for about 12 minutes. The service owner, Data Platform, led the response.

Timeline

- 09:18 First signal received.
- 09:21 Incident declared and on-call team engaged.
- 09:53 Likely cause identified.
- 10:14 Mitigation applied.
- 10:37 Service confirmed healthy and incident closed.

What happened

Investigation found that a pipeline overwrote the environment variable that pointed the service at its cache cluster.

Certificates were checked as part of triage and were valid.

The relevant alert had fired repeatedly the previous week and had been muted by the on-call engineer.

It took time to work out which team owned the affected component.

All traffic depended on one component with no standby.

What went well

Responders communicated clearly in the incident channel and the status page was updated within fifteen minutes of the incident being declared.

Actions

- Add a synthetic probe that exercises the affected path every minute.
- Move certificate renewal into the automated rotation pipeline.
- Write and rehearse a runbook for this failure mode.